

had such a great family that I immediately dismissed the rumors. But when I got to that door and saw Mitchell's face, I realized that things had gotten pretty bad—as bad as they can get.

“Come in, come in,” he said, ushering us inside. “I’ll introduce you to Meredith.”

Meredith? Linda shot me a glance and grabbed my arm.

Sitting at the table, in Judy's normal place, was a woman who looked under 30 years old. She flashed a megawatt smile and gushed about how she'd heard so much about us from Mitchell and how happy she was to meet us. At the far end of the table was Elliott, the Claytons' grown son, looking sullen. Their daughter, Elise, was absent.

“Where's Elise?” Savannah asked.

Mitchell looked at his feet. “Elise couldn't make it home this year. Says she's studying hard at university and that she was busy. The other families couldn't make it, either, I'm afraid, which is why I'm so grateful you guys didn't back out on me.” Mitchell finally found the courage to look up, and when he met my eye, I could see he was fighting back tears. Here was a man I'd known for years, a man who had had a solid family and, unbeknownst to me until that very moment, had seen it all fall apart in just a few months. How? Why? Nothing made any sense.

We approached the dining-room table where Meredith was sitting in Judy's place. Nobody asked about Judy. It was pretty clear she wouldn't be in attendance. The table was about as sad a sight as we'd ever seen. Normally, Judy created a gorgeous centerpiece with autumn wildflowers and maple leaves collected from their stunning property. Each person at the table usually had a name card made just for them, with a funny saying on it or cartoons drawn by Elise and Elliott. Not this year. The table was bare.

The whole night was a disaster. The house was eerily silent, so different from the boisterous joy of previous holidays. Elliott couldn't bring himself to sit down at the dinner table and was sitting off to the side in the living room, texting on his cell phone—something Judy would *never* have allowed. Meanwhile, Trevor had taken control of Elliott's video game console, and instead of hanging